



Watches oscillate – quietly

There's a new silent oscillator out there reducing the number of parts in a mechanical watch <http://dgit.in/SilentOscillator>

Screen number two

Researcher teams at MIT develop a smartphone system that lets you use your smartphone as a different second screen <http://dgit.in/THAWProject>

Geek life

Ads” and you’re shown a series of categorised boxes with click value on them. All the boxes have the same price of \$ 0.001 and a single Bonus Pack. The bonus pack is like a lottery of three ads which you have to watch. Any of them could get you free rewards in cash or kind. More ads would only be shown to us once the system ‘reset as per their server’ (whatever that means). Bottom line: we’re out of ads and have to wait. In the meanwhile, if we’re interested in betting on the lottery we can go on to watch the 99 advertisements (which we do – no luck). Effectively, we’ve watched 132 ads for \$ 0.033 payment (₹2.01) since lottery ads aren’t counted towards payments.

The prestige of the con

A few caveats: you can’t open multiple ads at once. You can’t go away from the ad window or else it will pause and resume only once you return. Not all ads are of the same length and you can’t withdraw money earned until you reach a minimum goal. The average time per ad is on average 30-45 seconds with a few reaching a full minute. Even switching to a VLC window to watch a movie will freeze the clock, so constant attention is expected. The minimum goal to withdraw is \$2, which would take 2000 ad views to reach. This translates to about 25 hours on non-stop clicking. There are, of course, ways out. Rent clicks, upgrade to Golden Membership or Rent Referrals. There lies the rub.

Never over-promising vast riches, providing a very clear means to perform tasks and keeping the task just easy enough filled with high degree of tedious obstacles – even the most enthusiastic time-wasters would feel better if they could just get some referrals or rented clicks. While on one hand the business of watching ads for pennies in payments is grossly under-paying, there is a long time investment before any payout can be expected. On the other hand, paying for Rented Referrals or Golden Memberships is a means to rent a part of other people’s clicks with no guarantee that the people whose clicks you’re renting are high performers. The fine print is masterfully used to defy all negligence or breach of legal expectations. Of all the websites that fell under our radar, FastRuppee and Neobux were the most perfectly pitched and most dangerous.

Even in the case of users who persevere through 2000 ads, we discovered that the payments were neither prompt nor easily obtained. Users were advised to redirect their funds towards the paid alternative. A review of online complaint boards led to reports of how the two dollars due for early-exit members was rarely ever paid. But even if it is paid, the amount would be ₹122 for 25 hours of work i.e. just under ₹5 per hour. The lowest minimum wage category in India earns over ₹20 per hour. Who wouldn’t feel compelled to rent clicks or referrals just so that the benefits of their underlings flows up to them? Except you aren’t told to directly interact with people and refer them to the website and doing it would place the liability of the scam on you, not the website.

Now, meet the amateurs

No other website was as professional pitched as FastRuppee and Neobux - plausible, doable and an utter time-vampire that pays pittance (if at all) for countless hours. The nature of the “scam” relies on persuading people to eventually pay out of their pockets for clicks and a Ponzi-like referral system. Other websites that made our lists were BharatOnlineWork.com and MoneyMail.com, and they are sheer amateurs in comparison.

BharatOnlineWork although seemingly legit quickly devolves on its web page into a needy, persuasive, half-witted con-man who’s trying to somehow convince users to shell out ₹1,490/- for a “Bharat Online Work Package” - a CD (remember those) which reassuringly has to be paid for on delivery.

Our third candidate website MoneyMail.in was slightly more clever (even if, eventually, a massive let down). The website requires users a chance to get paid for reading emails along with a host of other activities like being a Recharge Wallet agent - who will earn .5 to 1.5 percent on transactions when making recharges for cell phones, DTC and Data Cards. Participants simply need to deposit ₹500 or more via direct bank account transfer with no online payment gateway involved. If things weren’t fishy already we just hit the sushi bar on this one. Both BharatOnlineWork and MoneyMail use the same techniques used by other

notorious online portals like EarnPart-TimeJobs.com, Emailpays.com, Adsensejobs.com, Netjobs247.com and Emailreadingjob.com to lure unsuspecting customers. Most victims aren’t fluent in English and the perpetrators take advantage to confuse and convince them. More refined sites like Neobux prey on the inevitable boredom of users and offer short-term payoffs to lure users to make high value purchases. In both cases the users are encouraged to recruit others as a means to enhance their own earnings through referral.

What Have We Learned?

It’s a case of old wine in a new bottle, where the wine is poisoned and the bottle is a Molotov cocktail. If it seems too good to be true it probably is – a cliché, but true. Age-old scams are reinvented in the digital age to prey on the hopes of needy and desperate people. In times when getting a job is tough and even the employed are looking for a side income, it makes sense that these schemes bear fruit for online criminals. For a metropolitan internet-savvy user this may not prove a temptation but for the majority of people across the country this is proving to be a real danger. Thousands of rupees are sent by each person to these websites in the hopes that they will be able to find a sustained income for their future.

And despite how obvious and devious these fraudulent websites may seem, it has proved near impossible to punish or ban their promoters. Given the weak and obfuscated parameters of the Indian IT law and the understanding of the Internet by government officials the progress is slow. In many cases the URL domains are private and registered abroad with only the local bank account information being real. However, these accounts are under legal protection so that the account holder’s identity can’t be disclosed and banks can’t punish account owners unless a case of fraud has been registered.

In the end, the discouraged and financially desperate victims are left with no recourse but to absorb their losses and move on – which is exactly what these schemers are hoping for all along. When the process for persecuting the guilty is more complicated than the fraud itself, we can all agree that someone radically needs to bring justice to the system. ■